

WSJ Daily Briefing — Saturday, August 1, 2026

August 1, 2026

Executive Summary

The Iran war enters its sixth month with a fresh escalation order.: "Trump Orders Fresh Attack Against Iran as War Enters Sixth Month" — U.S. officials said the offensive could begin "as soon as this weekend," even as "Trump Pauses Iran Strikes as Officials Weigh Dwindling Air Defense Stocks" and "Iran Launches Surprise Missile Attack on U.S. Forces" shows Tehran gambling on escalation. The Pentagon's answer is procurement: over \$120 billion for Patriots and submarines.

The AI crown changed hands.: Berber Jin's "How OpenAI Lost Its AI Crown—and the Fight to Win It Back" reports Anthropic seized the lead by shipping coding agents while OpenAI chased consumer chatbots. The tape agreed: AMZN +15.32%, Microsoft's record +\$450 billion day, AAPL -7.35%.

The leveraged layer was purged.: "Situational Awareness Down 67% in July in AI Stock Rout" — "We let you down this month," Leopold Aschenbrenner's firm told investors after selling the bulk of its stocks to Citadel.

Warsh's honeymoon is over.: "Kevin Warsh's Honeymoon With the Bond Market Is Already Over" — investors demand proof of the inflation fight after Wednesday's selloff; "Warsh Floats Cut in Number of Fed Rate-Setting Meetings"; the Treasury warns banks it might intervene in dollar-yen.

Legacy institutions negotiate from weakness.: David Ellison fights the \$81 billion Paramount-Warner deal in open court; FIFA's Infantino reverses his private-capital plan under revolt; six Wachtell lawyers defect; Ford kills its "boring" cars; a new United Steelworkers president faces Nippon-owned U.S. Steel.

Cluster 1: Geopolitics & Defense

The sixth-month escalation ladder.: "Trump Orders Fresh Attack Against Iran as War Enters Sixth Month" — U.S. officials said the offensive could begin "as soon as this weekend." The escalation is two-sided: "Iran Launches Surprise Missile Attack on U.S. Forces" — Tehran gambles on escalation with a surprise attack, echoed in "Iran Gambles on Escalation With Surprise Attack on U.S. Forces" — and "Trump Pauses Iran Strikes as Officials Weigh Dwindling Air Defense Stocks" — U.S. officials weigh depleting air-defense stockpiles. Shelby Holliday and Laura J. Fong explain why "Iran's Workhorse Missile Is Becoming More Dangerous for U.S. Troops": the homemade Kheibar Shekan has complicated U.S. defense efforts across the Middle East. The Pentagon's answer is procurement — "Pentagon Commits Over \$120 Billion for Patriot Missiles, Submarines": the Army modified its Lockheed Martin contract to step up production, though "the final cost will depend on congressional funding" (Drew FitzGerald, Marcus Weisgerber). The editorial board sees the neglected flank: "Trump Looks Away From Iran's Allies" — the regime depends on its backers to keep waging war. *See also:* "Iran War Pushes Companies to Raise Prices on Beer, Paint, Fries and More" (Cluster 3) for the war's corporate P&L; channel.

Calibrated view: 60% probability of new U.S. strikes on Iran within 2 weeks — (rationale: "Trump Orders Fresh Attack" quotes officials saying the offensive "could begin as soon as this weekend," although the pause over "dwindling air defense stocks" creates execution uncertainty).

The peace plans hit the ground.: "Latest Gaza Peace Plan Runs Up Against Reality" — a new initiative faces hard obstacles on the ground. The Editorial Board's "The Gaza Road Map vs. Trump Peace Plan" notes the Board of Peace "offers new hope but doesn't always stick to the original terms." The West Bank is the violence vector: "Settlers Torch Mosques and Villagers Guard Homes: West Bank Violence Is Surging" — a deadly clash sparked fresh attacks on Palestinian villages in what critics call a push to expand Israeli territory (Anat Peled, Suha Ma'ayeh). In the Saturday

Interview, historian Simon Sebag Montefiore — no fan of Benjamin Netanyahu — says there won't be a Palestinian state for "decades": "We Live in 'a New World of Counterhistory'".

Calibrated view: 35% probability the Gaza peace plan produces a durable ceasefire within 6 months — (rationale: the plan "runs up against reality," West Bank settler violence is surging per Peled and Ma'ayeh, and Montefiore's "counterhistory" interview sees no Palestinian state "for decades").

Borders and the naval theater.: Spain is mopping up after an estimated 60,000 migrants surged from Morocco into Ceuta: "Spain Says Most Immigrants Who Overran Its African Enclave Have Left" — police and troops rounded up hundreds who remained (Benoit Faucon, David Luhnow) — and "Spain Regains Control of Enclave After Migrants Overrun It" (Luhnow, Margherita Stancati, Andrea Figueras). The Editorial Board's "The Moroccans Invade Spain" draws the political lesson. In the Pacific, "U.S., Allies Put Frictions Aside, Showing China Combined Naval Might" — multilateral exercises let Washington and allies practice working together and show they are doing more to bolster their own defenses (Timothy W. Martin). The human toll: "Ten Climbers Dead After Avalanche on Pakistan Mountain" — renowned climber Nirmal Purja and nine other mountaineers were killed on Thursday (Krishna Pokharel, Waqar Gillani). And a brutal war-crimes report: "How Russia Uses Sexual Violence to Wage War" — a report on Russia's wartime tactics.

Cluster 2: Markets & Macroeconomy

The AI accounting moment.: "HEARD ON THE STREET: Wall Street Thinks It Knows How Tech Giants Will Make AI Pay" — investors are coming around to the idea that Big Tech AI spending can make sense "as long as there is a cloud-computing business involved" (Asa Fitch). The earnings tape delivered the verdict: "U.S. MARKETS: Amazon and Apple Deliver the Drama to Close a Turbulent Month" — record market-cap moves for the tech giants end in a 1% Nasdaq gain (Shradha Dinesh, Sam Goldfarb); "MARKETS P.M.: Amazon Surges and Apple Falls on Latest Earnings" (Heard on the Street Staff). *See also: "How OpenAI Lost Its AI Crown—and the Fight to Win It Back" (Cluster 3) for the product-side succession behind the tape. AMZN +15.32% to \$271.58, GOOG +6.88%, MPWR +8.35%, ETN +7.32%, DXCM +11.95% led the S&P; 500; AAPL -7.35% to \$308.91, COIN -10.59%, GDDY -16.70%, CTVA -11.90%, EIX -6.81% lagged. "U.S. MARKETS: Microsoft Posts Biggest One-Day Market-Cap Gain for Any U.S. Company" — the software company gained \$450 billion in market value while Meta shares plunged (David Uberti). "MARKETS P.M.: AI Stocks Stage a Rebound" capped the volatile week.

Calibrated view: 70% probability the AI cap-ex winners' outperformance persists through Q3 2026 — (rationale: Fitch's Heard on the Street rule — AI spend pays only with a cloud business attached — matches the July 31 cross-section where AMZN +15.32% and GOOG +6.88% led while derivative names lagged).

The purge of the leveraged layer.: EXCLUSIVE "Situational Awareness Down 67% in July in AI Stock Rout" — "We let you down this month," Leopold Aschenbrenner's hedge-fund firm told investors after selling the bulk of its stocks to Citadel (Peter Rudegeair, Berber Jin). The backstory: "His Wedding Guests Were Arriving—Just as His \$45 Billion Fund Was Falling Apart" — the "Nostradamus of AI" took on too much leverage, leading to a crash he never saw coming (Jin, Rudegeair, Gregory Zuckerman, Anissa Gardizy). Jason Zweig's "THE INTELLIGENT INVESTOR: Buyer Beware: Private Funds Come With Big Tax Bills" — the advisers touting hot funds aren't always telling you what you need to know. A -67% month needs +200% to recover; the forced sale is a flow event behind today's dispersion.

Warsh and the end of the Fed put.: "Kevin Warsh's Honeymoon With the Bond Market Is Already Over" — investors warned the Fed must show commitment to the inflation fight after Wednesday's selloff (Sam Goldfarb). "Warsh Floats Cut in Number of Fed Rate-Setting Meetings" — meeting fewer than eight times a year would fit the chairman's goal of drawing less attention to the central bank. The Editorial Board cheers: "REVIEW & OUTLOOK: Warsh Makes Markets Do Their Job" — have investors "forgotten how to price risk without the Federal Reserve guiding them?" The Potomac Watch Podcast covers "The U.S. Hits Iran Again, as the Regime Widens its Aggression." The yen wildcard: "ECONOMY: Treasury Warns Banks It Might Intervene in Dollar-Yen Exchange Rate" — the Japanese currency has weakened to near multidecade lows (Matt Grossman, Ben Glickman).

Calibrated view: 55% probability the Treasury actually intervenes in dollar-yen within 6 months — (rationale: Grossman and Glickman report the Treasury "warns banks it might intervene" with the yen near multidecade lows; Warsh's lower-attention Fed posture reduces the odds of a rates-based defense).

Consolidated prediction table:

#	Prediction	Probability	Implied odds	Timeframe	Key evidence
1	New U.S. strikes on Iran begin	60%	3:2	2 weeks	"Trump Orders Fresh Attack"; "could begin as soon as this weekend"; air-defense stockpile pause
2	Gaza plan yields durable ceasefire	35%	7:13	6 months	Plan "runs up against reality"; West Bank surge; Montefiore "decades" interview
3	AI cap-ex winners keep outperforming	70%	7:3	Q3 2026	Fitch Heard on the Street; AMZN +15.32%, GOOG +6.88% vs AAPL -7.35%
4	Treasury intervenes in dollar-yen	55%	11:9	6 months	Grossman, Glickman; yen at multidecade lows
5	Paramount-Warner merger closes	50%	1:1	12 months	Ellison courtroom strategy; states-drop-out options; Newsom concerns

Cluster 3: Business & Tech Strategy

The crown fight.: "How OpenAI Lost Its AI Crown—and the Fight to Win It Back" — bets on consumer chatbots and flashy side projects overshadowed the AI coding opportunity, which rival Anthropic used to capture the lead (Berber Jin). The science desk adds a human angle: BEN COHEN | SCIENCE OF SUCCESS: "The Math Superstar Who's Terrified of AI—and Just Took a Job at OpenAI" — a noted mathematician joins OpenAI despite fears about AI. Holman W. Jenkins Jr.'s BUSINESS WORLD column, "Open Weight and AI's Coming Chernobyl Moment", urges U.S. intelligence agencies to tell us what they know about the Chinese models. And "The Red-Hot Book at the Center of an AI Mystery" — fourteen publishers fought over Jerry Falade's debut novel; after it sold, his agent pulled support over AI concerns.

The war-inflation pipeline.: "Iran War Pushes Companies to Raise Prices on Beer, Paint, Fries and More" — Sherwin-Williams and the brewer of Samuel Adams are among those facing higher commodity and freight costs (Ryan Dezember). This is the input-cost channel: war inflation arrives at producer inputs before CPI. "California Lettuce Growers Skip Harvest, Plow Their Crops Back Into the Ground" — federal health authorities haven't linked U.S. produce to cyclospora, but consumers are steering clear (Amira McKee).

Courts, deals and the renegotiation.: "David Ellison's Risky Strategy to Save His \$81 Billion Warner Deal" — also reported as "David Ellison's Risky Courtroom Strategy to Save His \$81 Billion Warner Deal" — after opting to go straight to trial, his team has added legal muscle, gaming out options such as getting states to drop out of the suit to get the Paramount-Warner merger done (Jessica Toonkel, Joe Flint). EXCLUSIVE: "Newsom Expresses Concerns About State Antitrust Suit Against Paramount" — California's governor voices concerns. "FIFA Scraps Controversial

Plan to Sell Commercial Rights to Private Investors" — soccer chief Gianni Infantino reversed course mere days after the world learned of his proposal; Europe's governing body hinted strongly that he should resign. "JPMorgan's Pitch to Put a Value on FIFA" — the bank's presentation said soccer's global governing body could more than double players and competitions under the now-canceled spinoff plan (Gina Heeb, Joshua Robinson). Emma Tucker's THE 10-POINT: "The Revolt That Brought Down FIFA's Grand Plan" — plus Trump's fresh Iran order and the law-firm defections shocking the legal world.

Industry in motion.: "Six Lawyers Switched Firms and Big Law Will Never Be the Same" — the defections from Wachtell reflect a broader trend of elite New York firms losing ground to bigger rivals (Erin Mulvaney). "Ford Made Boring Cars Popular. It Doesn't Want Them Anymore." — the maker of the Mustang and Bronco wants a lineup of such "passionate" vehicles; gone are staid family sedans, cheap hatchbacks or frumpy minivans (Ryan Felton). "Rumble Seat | America's Favorite Compact SUV Just Ditched the Gas-Only Option" — the compact SUV segment shifts as the gas-only option disappears. "She Never Worked in a Steel Mill. Now She Leads the United Steelworkers." — new union leader Roxanne Brown's first test will be contract negotiations with U.S. Steel under its new Japanese ownership (Bob Tita). EXCLUSIVE: "Tesla Weighs Sale of China Business to Pave Way for Potential SpaceX Merger" — Tesla considers selling its China operations to enable a SpaceX merger. "Financial Services Roundup: Market Talk" covers bitcoin ETFs and large private-equity firms. And a human-interest coda: "A Florida Surrogate, a Father in China, and the Babies Caught Between" — a surrogate arrangement raises cross-border legal and custody questions.

Calibrated view: 50% probability the Paramount-Warner merger closes within 12 months — (rationale: Toonkel and Flint report Ellison's team is "gaming out options such as getting states to drop out of the suit," and Newsom's expressed concerns suggest political flexibility — but trial uncertainty remains the swing factor).

Cluster 4: Policy & Opinion

The fundraising machine and the Michigan fight.: EXCLUSIVE: "The Boss Wants This Money': Inside Trump's Unprecedented Fundraising Operation" — a look inside the Trump fundraising machine. The party fight: "ESSAY: Michigan Primary Is a Fight for the Future of the Democrats" — the two candidates represent dueling visions of a party in crisis; "These Democratic Voters Battle Over What Party Stands For" — voters in the Michigan primary are split over the party's direction.

The Fauci drama and the cultural fights.: Peggy Noonan's DECLARATIONS: "Anthony Fauci Unmasks Himself" — his diaries make clear he saw the pandemic less as a historic emergency than a media opportunity. The editorial "Dr. Fauci Takes the Fifth, Alas" follows. "Santos Settles Claim Over 'Manipulative Activity' on Kalshi" — the former congressman will pay more than \$35,000 to settle a regulator's claim he manipulated wagers on whether he would attend the State of the Union. "The Smithsonian's Disdain for America" (Jeffrey H. Anderson) meets "Trump Has a Point About the Smithsonian" (Columnist). Free Expression: "Milton Friedman Was Right" (Matthew Continetti); "Weed Is the New Booze" (Mary Julia Koch); "America the Good" (Matthew Hennessey).

The economic catechism.: The Editorial Board's "The Tepid Trump Economy" — the economy under Trump remains tepid — and "China's Non-Plan for the Economy" — Beijing lacks a coherent economic plan. "CROSS COUNTRY: Politicians Exploit Low Voter Turnout to Raise Taxes" (Michael J. Reitz); "Editorial: Missouri Could Be the Next State to Eliminate Its Income Tax." Letters: "Our Legislation Is Against China, Not Mercedes Benz" — trade policy targets China, not German automakers; "Where Sec. 232 Tariffs Undermine U.S. Industry"; "With the Saudis, Trump Could Repeat America's 'Atoms for Peace' Error" — remember who gave Iran nuclear know-how in the first place. "REVIEW & OUTLOOK: John Thune's Confirmation Fast Track" — the new 'en bloc' route has sped hundreds of Trump's confirmations. "REVIEW & OUTLOOK: Replimune's Melanoma Therapy Gets a Thumbs Up" — an advisory committee sides with patients over the FDA bureaucracy. "Editorial: Democrats Turn Against Direct Democracy." James Freeman's BEST OF THE WEB TODAY: "Another Defunder Says She's Changed."

The ideas section.: "COMMENTARY: From Lunar Landing to Lunar Land Rights" (John Chisholm, Dan Garretson); "Columnist: Now America Builds a 'Great Firewall'" — America erects its own digital barriers; "Columnist: Hollywood's Rule of Lawfare" (Holman W. Jenkins Jr.); "Notable & Quotable: Global Warming and Sleep"; "SUMATHI REDDY | YOUR HEALTH: Testosterone Testing: Who Needs It and Who Doesn't" — as the Defense Department plans

widespread screenings, doctors say most healthy men don't need routine tests. "The Rising Number of Uninsured Patients Starts to Hit Hospitals" — millions dropped their Affordable Care Act plans when subsidies expired and now struggle to pay. And the art desk: ART REVIEW: "'Avery, Gottlieb & Rothko: By the Sea' Review: Illuminating an Unlikely Kinship" — at the Cape Ann Museum, the overlooked connection between the three artists, forged during shared summers in Gloucester, Mass. "Prosecutors Drop Case Against Olympian Charged With Vandalizing Reflecting Pool" — the U.S. Attorney's Office in D.C. said new information showed the damage resulted from a botched installation, not vandalism. Zlati Meyer's What's News adds the morning's framing: "Trump Orders Fresh Strikes on Iran to Spur Surrender" — plus Spain's control of Ceuta and the unraveling of Situational Awareness.

Confirmations

Market data note

Stock prices, S&P; 500 leaders/laggards percentages, bond yields, and oil prices are from WSJ Markets section data tables (CDP-extracted) for the July 31, 2026 close. Index closes (DJIA 52,485.03 +0.53%; S&P; 500 7,489.72 +0.70%; NASDAQ 25,373.85 +1.00%; Russell 2000 2,931.34 -0.50%) and the leader/laggard tables reflect the July 31, 2026 U.S. session. The Microsoft "+\$450 billion one-day market-cap gain" is as reported by WSJ's David Uberti; the July 31 leader table (AMZN, DXCM, MPWR, ETN, GOOG) reflects the session's top movers. The Aschenbrenner -67% July figure is as reported by Rudegeair and Jin.

Sources

Inputs: `wsj\_stories.md` (Phase A; WSJ Homepage, World, Business, Markets, Opinion + Market Data appendix), `wsj\_connector.md`, `wsj\_analysis.md`, `wsj\_philosophy.md`, `wsj\_strategy.md`, `wsj\_operations.md` (Phase B profiles). Quoted phrases are attributable to named journalists per `wsj_stories.md` (Jin; Holliday, Fong; FitzGerald, Weisgerber; Peled, Ma'ayeh; Faucon, Luhnnow; Luhnnow, Stancati, Figueras; Martin; Pokharel, Gillani; Fitch; Dinesh, Goldfarb; Uberti; Rudegeair, Jin; Zuckerman, Gardizy; Zweig; Goldfarb; Grossman, Glickman; Dezember; McKee; Toonkel, Flint; Heeb, Robinson; Tucker; Mulvaney; Felton; Tita; Noonan; Continetti; Koch; Hennessey; Reitz; Reddy; Meyer), the Editorial Board, or quoted subjects (Aschenbrenner's firm, Warsh, Montefiore, Infantino, Brown, Ellison, Newsom).

Method note

Assembled by the WSJ Writer in the four-cluster structure from the six Phase A/B files. "Calibrated view" probabilities are analyst judgments grounded in article-specific evidence, expressed as percentages with implied odds. Cross-cluster links use See also: markers where related stories sit across clusters (the Iran war spans Geopolitics and the business price-hike story; the AI crown story spans Business and Markets). Forward-looking statements (strikes "as soon as this weekend," the dollar-yen intervention warning) retain future or modal tense per their sources.

Disclaimer

Analytical digest of WSJ reporting for institutional investors, corporate decision-makers and policy elites. Not investment advice. Market data are as reported at extraction time and may be revised. Predictions are probabilistic judgments, not certain forecasts.

观察者评论

翟东升——体系/结构视角

翟东升观察：2026年8月1日

美股"AI王冠易主"，底层逻辑是流动性退潮下的存量博弈，不是技术竞赛。Anthropic靠编码智能体超越OpenAI、微软单日市值增4500亿美元，亚马逊涨15.32%、苹果跌7.35%——这不是AI的问题，是资本抢登高地的结构性问题。杠杆层被清算：对冲基金单月亏67%。

Warsh与债市的蜜月结束，财政部威胁干预美元兑日元：美联储不是独立央行，而是债务结构的囚徒，加息则付息成本爆表，降息则通胀失控，这是结构性两难。美元不是商品背书，而是主权信用背书；伊朗战事进入第六个月，军事开支膨胀令主权信用系统性钙化。

派拉蒙与华纳的法庭缠斗、FIFA资本化流产，是旧制度熵增的症候。人民币崛起是结构性的，只是美元体系瓦解的副产品。

金灿荣——美国政治/战略相持视角

金灿荣观察：2026年8月1日

各位朋友，今天聊一聊。美国打伊朗打到第六个月，导弹库存见底，五角大楼转头批了一千二百亿美元买爱国者和潜艇。你们看啊，这就是战略相持——谁也吃不掉谁，就看谁家底先扛不住。

为什么伊朗能跟美国耗六个月？这个事情其实很简单：打仗打的是工业化，不是嘴硬。美国工业化空心化，导弹打一枚少一枚，扩产还得看国会脸色。就像冰箱空了还掀桌子，掀完还得去邻居家借米。

再看西太平洋，美国拉着盟友演习秀肌肉。要我说，心里没底才人多壮胆。特斯拉还盘算卖掉中国业务——美国人现在很焦虑，这恰恰说明中国大市场 and 完整工业体系的分量。

中国要做的就是把自己的事情做好。用实力赢来的平等才靠得住，这就是大变局的本质。我们赢了。

宋鸿兵——货币/债务/周期视角

宋鸿兵观察：2026年8月1日

财政部警告银行可能干预美元兑日元。日元跌至数十年低点，而日本正是美债最大持有者——美元环流的关键一环正在卡壳。这不是日元的问题，而是整个系统的问题：强如美元，如今要靠行政之手维护；干预汇率，就是给单点故障打补丁。

再看美联储：瓦尔什蜜月结束，债市要求反通胀实据，他却削减议息次数，等于拆掉压力表。通胀阀门失守，美元购买力便失去锚。

市场分化同样危险：微软单日市值暴增4500亿美元，苹果却跌7.35%；"情境意识"基金7月亏67%，被迫清仓给城堡——杠杆层出清，资本集中少数AI赢家，本身就是单点故障。

伊朗战争推高油漆、啤酒成本，五角大楼再批1200亿美元采购——战争开支与通胀互相强化，终以增发美元为代价。美元环流的逆转，正是从这些孤立事件开始。

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